

U6-Z6 Treasury Futures Roll Outlook

Bearish FV, TY; Bullish TU, UXY, US; Neutral WN

Asset manager net longs have been mixed across the complex, with intermediates higher in TY while TU fell as the policy outlook shifted toward hikes. There is switch risk in US and there could be value in the WN wild card, given the potential catalyst for large rate moves during the FOMC presser.

Andres Mok, CFA

+1 212 526 8690

andres.mok@barclays.com

BCI, US

Amrut Nashikkar

+1 212 412 1848

amrut.nashikkar@barclays.com

BCI, US

Outlook for U6-Z6 futures calendar rolls

Since the previous futures rolls cycle (M6-U6), oil prices have declined from their highs, though market sentiment remains sensitive to geopolitical developments in the Middle East. Fed Chair Warsh assumed leadership in June and underscored the Fed's commitment to price stability while signaling a preference for less forward guidance and, as a result, markets may need to find their own footing. Treasury yields have moved higher since, led by the long end as 30y yields reached their highest levels in two decades.

Asset managers' net long positions have been mixed across the futures complex. Long positions in TU have continued to decline and are at the lowest over the past year as the Fed outlook has shifted from cuts to hikes, and positions are more price-sensitive. Intermediate sector long positions increased, notably in TY, with the latest CFTC reading at 50%, the highest historically. In the bond sector, US positions rebounded while WN is mostly unchanged.

Funding and liquidity conditions. Funding conditions remain supportive with soft repo rates reflecting abundant cash and balance sheet capacity. We therefore do not expect funding pressures to impede rolls performance over the next few weeks.

Fed pricing sensitivity. Fed policy expectations remain sensitive to economic data and geopolitical headlines, the latter through the inflation impact from oil prices. We estimate that a 10bp flattening (steepening) in the forward repo curve between U6 and Z6 could impart about 0.5 ticks richening (cheapening) bias on the calendar rolls.

Overall, we are bearish FV, TY; bullish TU, TN/UXY, US; and neutral WN. A risk to our bearish (bullish) calendar views is the curve steepening (flattening).

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- **Bullish TU:** Asset managers' net longs have continued to trend lower as the Fed's outlook has shifted toward hikes. Positions are more price-sensitive than in recent cycles. We are bullish on the calendar roll.
- **Bearish FV:** Asset managers have increased long positions after they bottomed in the last cycle. Early delivery is optimal in both contracts, given the lower coupons. We think the richening of the roll provides an attractive opportunity for AM to roll their positions. We are bearish on the calendar roll.
- **Bearish TY:** Asset managers' positions have increased notably this cycle with the latest reading at nearly 50% of open interest — the highest historically. We think momentum is in the direction of further cheapening of the calendar roll.
- **Bullish TN/UXY:** Asset managers' net long positions are close to historical highs and positions are more price-insensitive than in recent cycles. However, these positions generally fall heading into the roll period. We think front net basis is a touch high with room to fall. We are bullish on the roll.
- **Bullish US:** Asset managers' net longs have increased to their highest over the past year and positions are a touch more price-insensitive. There is switch risk in the US contract with long-end yields above 5.0%. A large sell-off could extend the CTD further out the US basket while a rate rally could shorten it. We think the back basis should remain high given the switch risk, which is bullish for the calendar roll.
- **Neutral WN:** Asset managers' net long positions are mostly unchanged while positions are more price-insensitive. Nov52 is currently the CTD in both the back and front contracts. The September FOMC meeting could be a catalyst for larger rate moves as was the case at the July meeting and Fed Chair's remarks could drive a rate rally and trigger the wild card¹ exercise. We are neutral on the calendar rolls.

FIGURE 1. Summary of views

	Cheapest to deliver		Market Price	DV01		DV01		Direction for hedged calendar rolls
	Front	Back	32nds	Front	Back	\$/bp,100k	Tail, %	
TU	4.125 Jun28	4.625 Sep28	3.6	18	20	2.3	12.7%	Bullish
FV	3.500 Nov30	3.500 Feb31	3.5	42	43	1.8	4.3%	Bearish
TY	4.250 May33	4.375 Jul33	8.3	63	64	1.4	2.2%	Bearish
TN	4.125 Feb36	4.375 May36	10.5	84	86	1.7	2.0%	Bullish
US	4.750 Feb45	4.750 Feb45	16.0	128	128	-0.3	-0.2%	Bullish
WN	4.000 Nov52	4.000 Nov52	13.0	161	160	-0.4	-0.2%	Neutral

Note: As of 8/13/2026, AM levels.
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

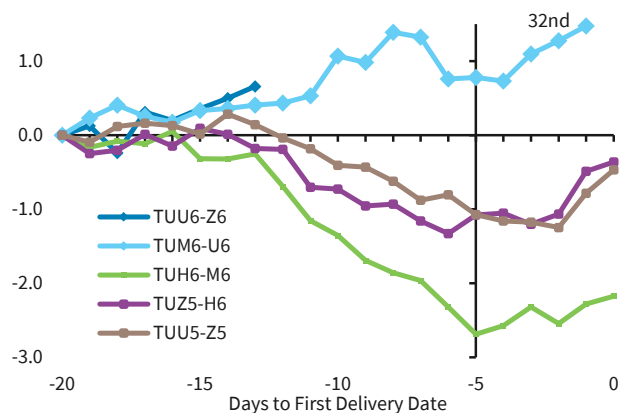
TU U6-Z6: Bullish

- **Direction:** The hedged calendar has typically exhibited a cheapening bias heading into the peak roll cycle. However, asset managers have been paring long positions in recent cycles and have not exerted much cheapening pressure on the roll. In the last cycle (M6-U6), the hedged calendar richened and we think the current cycle will follow a similar pattern as it has modestly richened (Figure 2).

¹ The "wild card" option allows the short seller of a Treasury futures contract to benefit from after-hours moves in the underlying bonds during the delivery period.

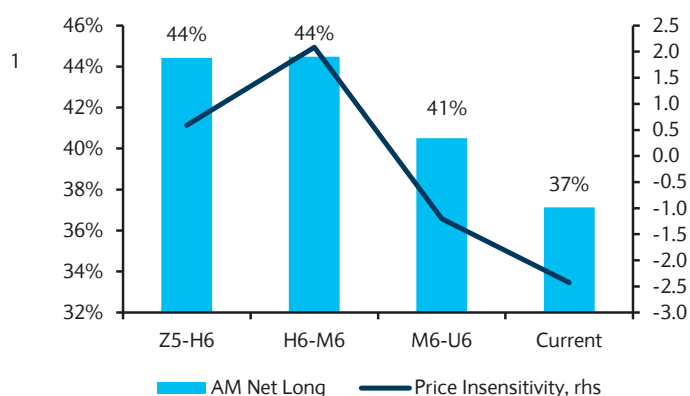
- Positioning:** 2y Treasury yields have risen back above 4.0%, their highest since early 2025 amid the continued conflict in the Middle East, elevated oil prices, and the Fed shifting its outlook towards hikes. Asset managers have pared long positions further this cycle with open interest falling to under 40% (Figure 3). However, positions have grown more price-sensitive as front-end yields have increased. The roll pace is slower than recent cycles (Figure 4).
- Relative value:** The front CTD is 4.125 Jun28, which are old2s, with 4.00 Jun28 (seasoned 5s) being a close contender. In the back contract, the 4.625 Sep28 (seasoned 5s) are the CTD. The front CTD has been cheapening relative to the back CTD on the spline; however, the spread is lower than in recent cycles. We think the reduced AM net long positions that are price-sensitive will exert less cheapening pressure on the rolls this time (Figure 5).
- Recommendation:** Overall, we are bullish on the roll.

FIGURE 2. Changes in the TU calendar heading into futures roll periods



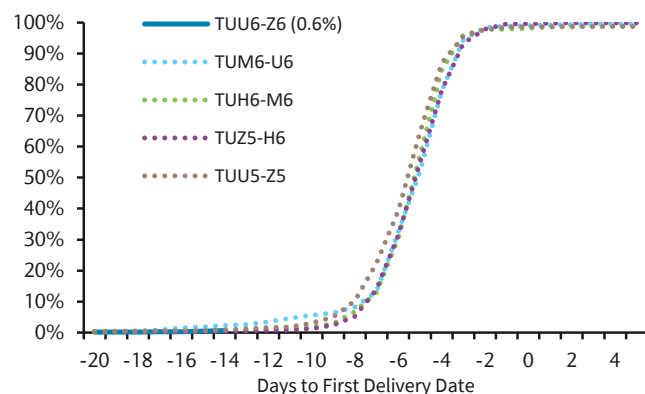
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 3. TU AM long positions and price-insensitivity index during calendar roll periods



Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

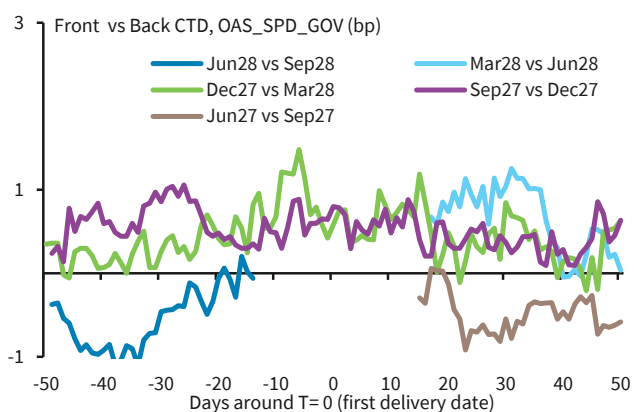
FIGURE 4. Open interest rolled into back contract (%)



Hedged rolls shown

Source: CFTC, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 5. TU front versus back CTD performance



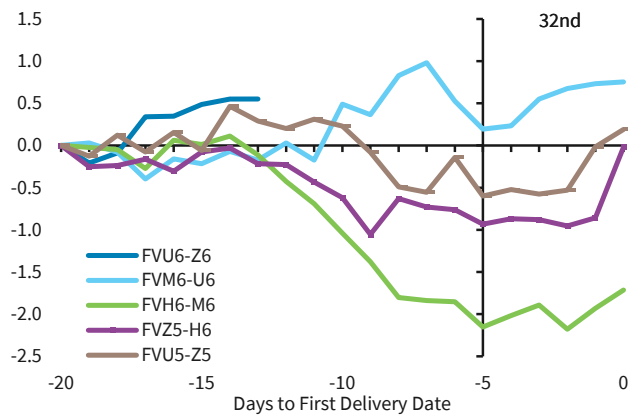
Lower: Front richens vs. back, Higher: Front cheapens vs. back

Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FV U6-Z6: Bearish

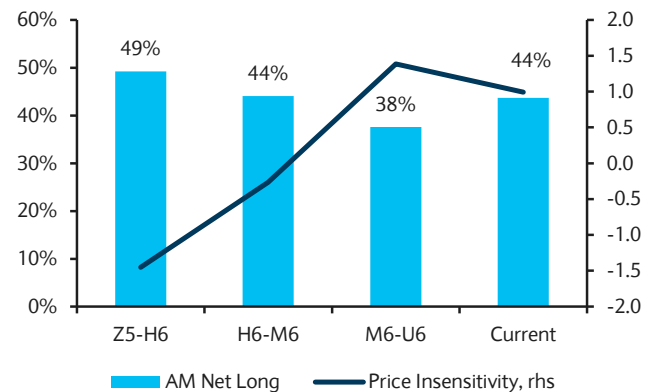
- **Direction:** The calendar has mostly cheapened of late heading into the peak of the roll cycle. In the current cycle, the hedged roll has richened (Figure 6) and we think this provides an attractive opportunity for longs to roll forward.
- **Positioning:** Asset managers' net long positions have rebounded since the last cycle and are back to above 40%. Positions are price-insensitive but less so than last time (Figure 7). Roll activity is slower than recent cycles (Figure 8).
- **Relative value:** Early delivery is optimal in FV given the low coupons in the contract CTDs. The front CTD (Feb31) has cheapened relative to the back CTD (Nov30) in RV (Figure 9), though it is still richer than at the same point in recent cycles. Although early delivery is optimal, leveraged investors may want to hold long basis positions into the delivery period for a larger payoff from the wild card option.
- **Recommendation:** Overall, we are bearish on the roll.

FIGURE 6. Changes in the FV calendar heading into futures roll periods



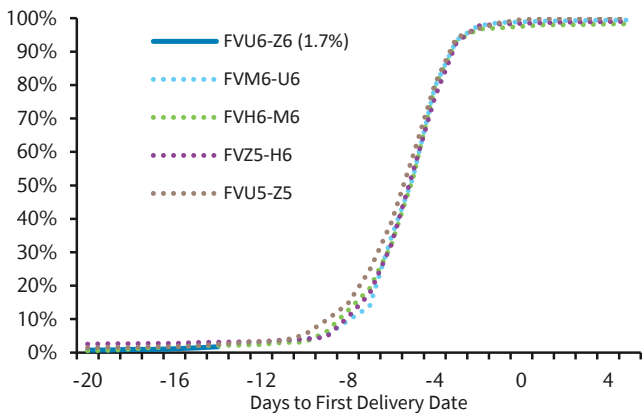
Hedged rolls shown
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 7. FV AM long positions and price-insensitivity index during calendar roll periods



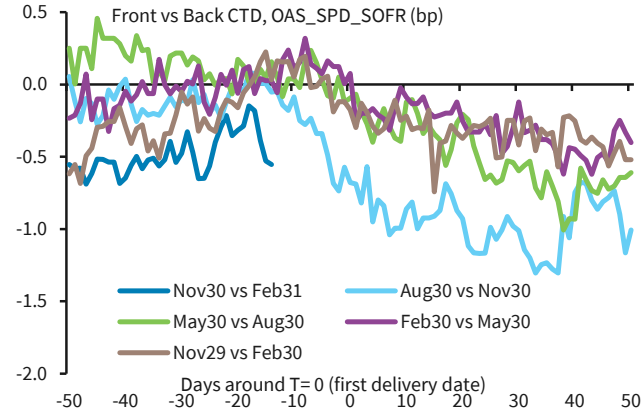
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 8. Open interest rolled into back contract (%)



Source: CFTC, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 9. FV front versus back CTD performance

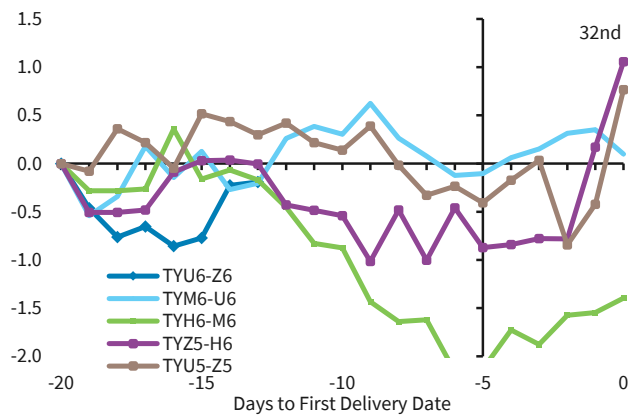


Lower: Front richens vs. back, Higher: Front cheapens vs. back
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

TY U6-Z6: Bearish

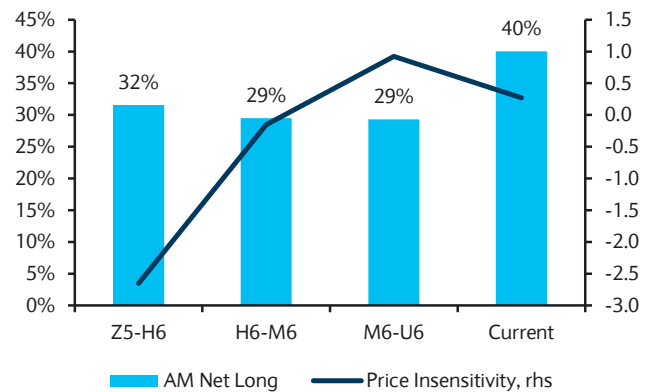
- **Direction:** The hedged calendar has exhibited a bearish bias in recent roll cycles. The roll has cheapened modestly and we believe momentum is in the direction of further cheapening of the calendar roll (Figure 10).
- **Positioning:** Asset managers' net longs saw a notable increase, rising from around 30% of open interest to an average of 40% in the current cycle, with the latest reading showing nearly 50%, the highest historically. Positions are price-insensitive but less than in the last cycle (Figure 11). The roll pace is in line with recent cycles (Figure 12).
- **Relative value:** The front CTD is May33 and the back CTD is Jul33, both from the 7y series. In relative value, the front CTD is trading rich to the back CTD and has been moving sideways. We think there's room for the front CTD to cheapen, which is bearish for the calendar roll (Figure 13).
- **Recommendation:** Overall, we are bearish on the calendar roll.

FIGURE 10. Changes in the TY calendar heading into futures roll periods

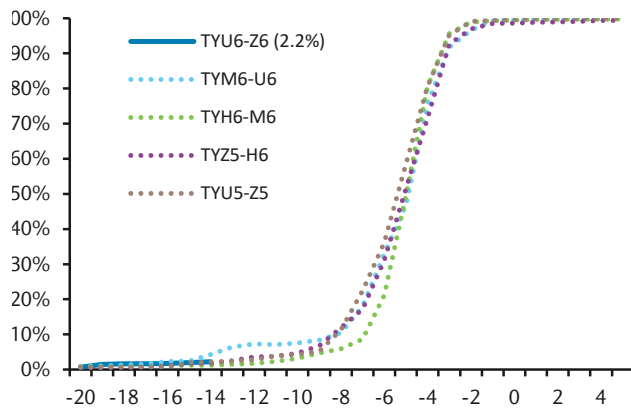


Hedged rolls shown
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

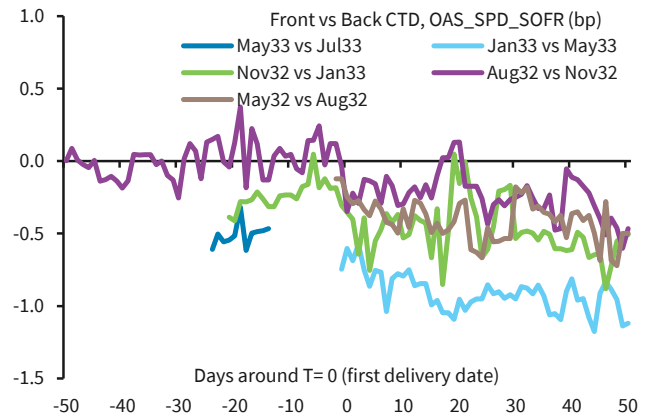
FIGURE 11. TY AM long positions and price-insensitivity index during calendar roll periods



Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 12. Open interest rolled into back contract (%)

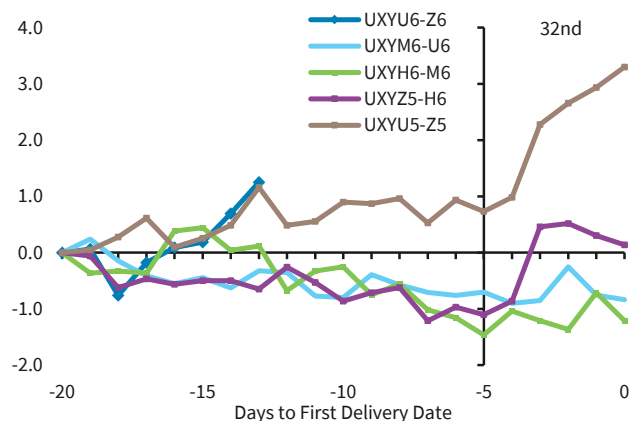
Source: CFTC, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 13. TY front versus back CTD performance

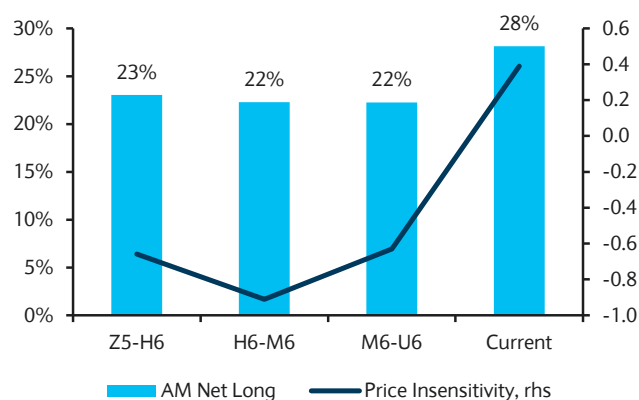
Lower: Front richens vs. back, Higher: Front cheapens vs. back
 Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

TN/UXY U6-Z6: Bullish

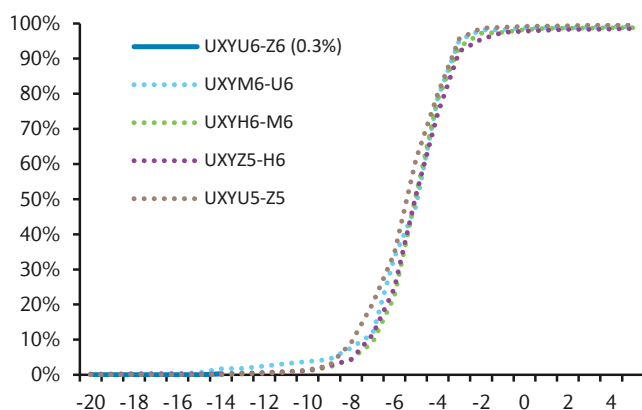
- Direction:** The calendar rolls have been, for the most part, exhibiting more of a cheapening bias in recent cycles over the past year. In the current cycle, the roll appears to have a bullish impulse, with the 7s10s curve steepening. We think there is room for it to continue in that direction (Figure 14).
- Positioning:** Asset managers' net long positions have risen to about 30% of open interest, which is close to the historical high. As has been the case in recent cycles, these positions generally fall into the roll period. Positions are also more price-insensitive than in recent cycles (Figure 15). There has not been much roll activity so far (Figure 16).
- Relative value:** The front CTD is the double Old10s (Feb36) and the back CTD is the off-the-run 10y (May36) that recently came off benchmark status. The front/back CTD spread is trading in line with recent cycles (Figure 17). Front net basis is a touch high and we think there is room for it to fall heading into the roll cycle, which is bullish for the roll.
- Recommendation:** Overall, we are bullish on the roll.

FIGURE 14. Changes in the TN calendar heading into futures roll periods


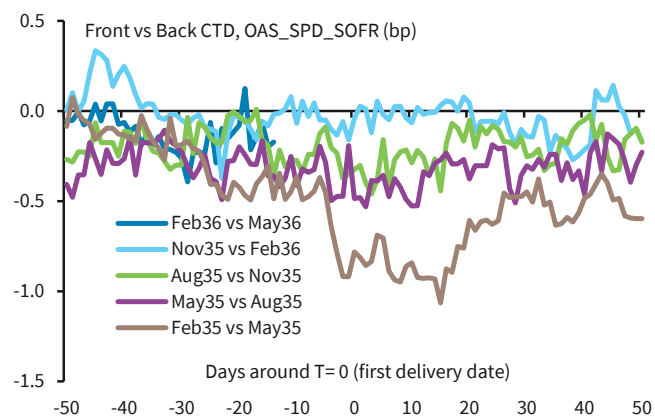
Hedged rolls shown
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 15. TN AM long positions and price-insensitivity index during calendar roll periods


Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 16. Open interest rolled into back contract (%)


Source: CFTC, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 17. UXY front versus back CTD performance


Lower: Front richens vs. back, Higher: Front cheapens vs. back.
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

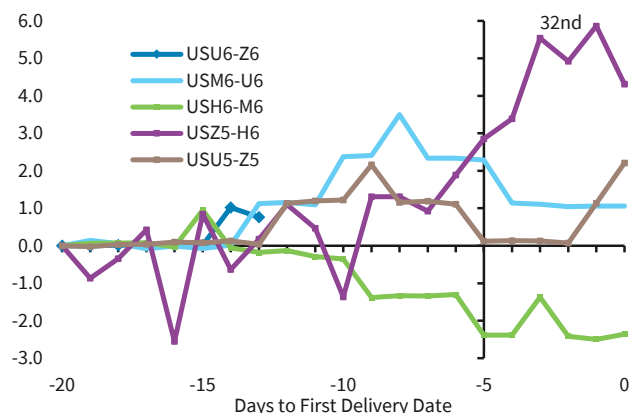
US U6-Z6: Bullish

- Direction:** The hedged calendar roll has mostly exhibited a richening bias in recent cycles. In the current cycle, the roll is mostly unchanged. We think there is momentum for the roll to richen heading into the first delivery date (Figure 18).
- Positioning:** Asset managers' net long positions edged up towards 25% of open interest, the highest in the past year. Positions are now a touch price-insensitive (Figure 19). The roll pace is a touch faster than in recent cycles (Figure 20).
- Relative value:** There is switch risk in the US sector given the recent long-end sell-off and yields above 5.0%. The securities in the basket are relatively close CTD candidates in both contracts. For instance, the CTD is currently the 4.75% May45 (20y) with the CTDs in the 44-45 sector being close contenders. In a larger sell-off, the CTDs could extend towards the 2046 sector and then subsequently to the 2050 sector. In a sufficient rate rally, the CTD would shorten to 4.75 Nov43.

The net basis is lowest in the 2045 maturity sector. In a rate sell-off, the basis for securities beyond 2045 should narrow as those become increasingly likely to be CTDs. In a rate rally, the basis for securities shorter than 2045 should narrow (Figure 21). Overall, we believe there should be greater optionality in the back contract, which should keep Z6 cheaper relative to U6, imparting a bullish bias on the roll.

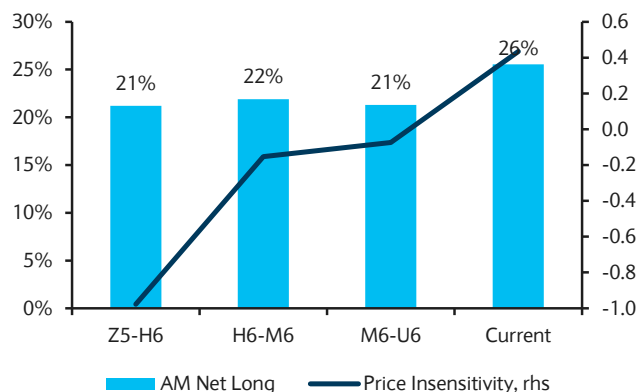
- **Recommendation:** Overall, we are bullish on the roll.

FIGURE 18. Changes in the US calendar heading into futures roll periods



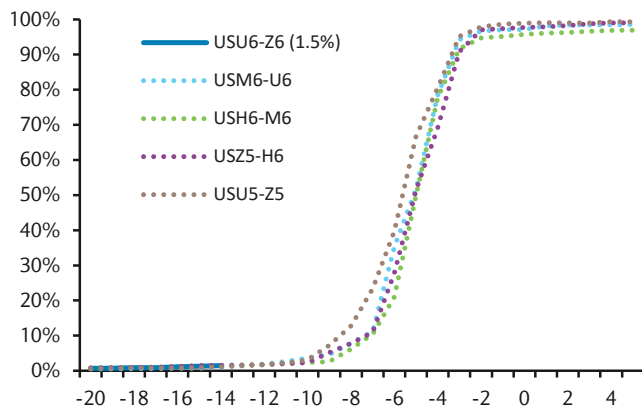
Hedged rolls shown.
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 19. US AM long positions and price-insensitivity index during calendar roll periods



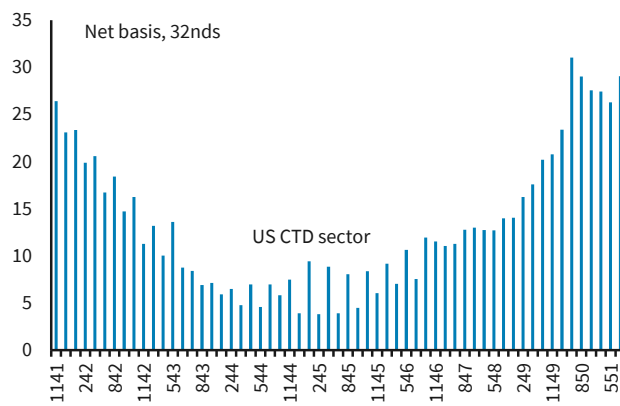
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 20. Open interest rolled into the back contract (%)



Source: CFTC, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 21. The CTD sector in the US basket is in the 2044-2045 maturity sector



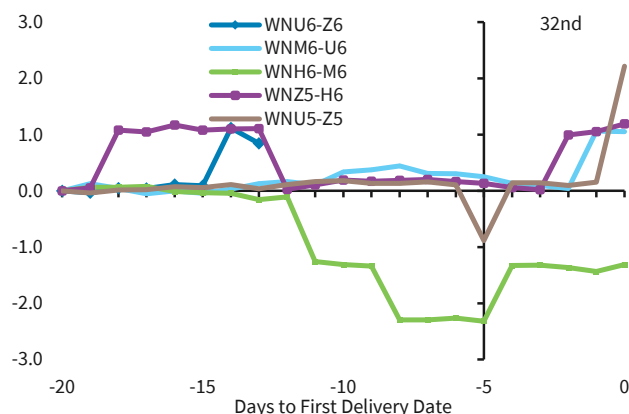
Each security in US basket is priced to last delivery using term repo
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

WN U6-Z6: Neutral

- **Direction:** The WN calendar rolls have been mixed in recent cycles and there has not been much movement heading into the peak of the roll period save for the H6-M6 cycle. In the current cycle, the roll has richened a touch (Figure 22).

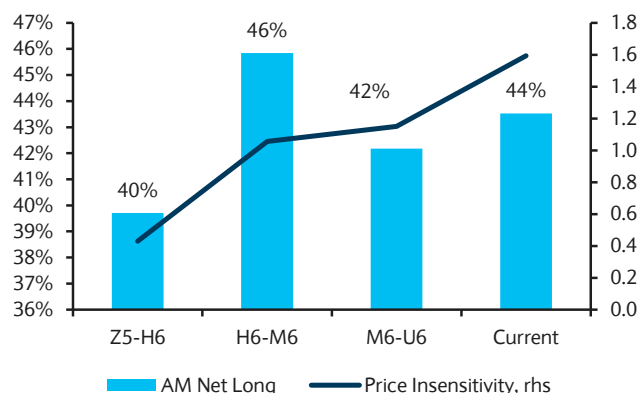
- **Positioning:** Asset managers' net long positions have been mostly unchanged in recent cycles and positions are more price-insensitive than in recent cycles (Figure 23). The roll pace is similar to recent cycles (Figure 24).
 - **Relative value:** At current yield levels, Nov52 is currently the CTD in both the front and back contract. There needs to be a sufficient rally at the long-end for the CTD to switch back to Nov53 in both contracts. In a sell-off, the CTD would switch to the shortest maturity sector in the basket, Nov51 in U6 and Feb52 in Z6.
 - *Wild card delivery:* Higher rate vol during the 3-5pm session points to higher wild card option value (Figure 25). The next FOMC meeting could be a source of uncertainty for markets and could become a catalyst for larger rate moves, as was the case at the July FOMC meeting, which sparked a sharp sell-off at the long-end. A rate rally in the 3-5pm session could trigger the wild card exercise.
- Separately, if long-end rates sell off about 25bp or so heading into the delivery period, the CTD could switch to the low coupon 1.875 Nov51. Given the lower conversion factor, there is a larger residual tail (1- CF) in the Nov51 basis. Thus, a smaller rate rally is needed for the wild card option to be in the money in the post session.
- **Recommendation:** Overall, we are neutral on the roll.

FIGURE 22. Changes in the WN calendar heading into futures roll periods



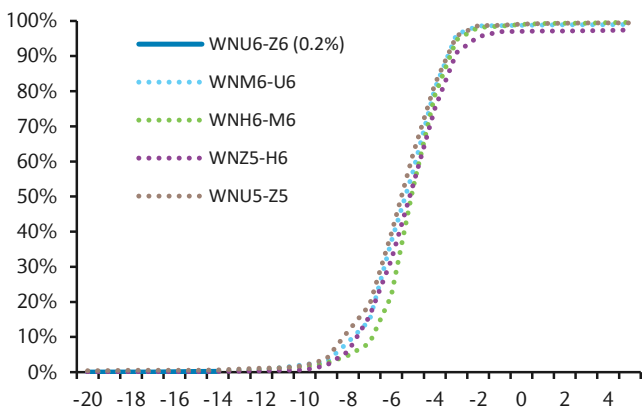
Hedged rolls shown
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 23. WN AM long positions and price-insensitivity index during calendar roll periods



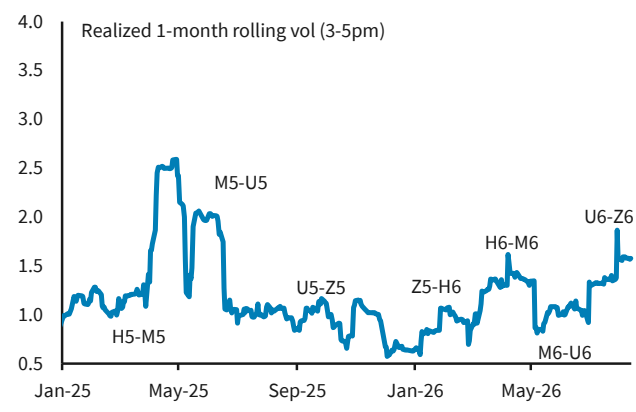
Source: CFTC, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 24. Open interest rolled into back contract (%)



Source: CFTC, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 25. Realized one-month vol of 30y rate moves between 3pm and 5pm have risen



Source: Barclays Research

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